

Course Overview & Study Guide

BCPC 305 — Principles of Leadership | Level 200 | Semester 1, 2025/2026

This guide walks through the official course outline for Principles of Leadership and explains what each part actually means for you as a student — not just what's listed, but why it matters and how to use it to plan your semester.

1. What This Course Is About

Leadership is treated here as a practical skill, not just a theory topic. The course argues that how well an organisation survives tough conditions often comes down to how well it's led — so the point isn't to memorise definitions, but to understand how leadership actually works: how leaders think, how they earn trust, how they make decisions, and how those decisions play out in real organisations and in Ghana's own traditional systems.

You'll move between theory (models developed by researchers) and practice (real leaders and case studies), so expect exam questions that ask you to apply a theory to a scenario, not just define it.

2. Course Objectives — What the Course Is Trying to Do For You

The official objectives can read like a checklist, so here's what each one actually means in practice:

- **Understand leadership and its levels** — you'll learn that leadership isn't one-size-fits-all; a team lead, a department head, and a CEO all "lead," but differently.
- **Explore traditional leadership in Ghana** — chieftaincy and traditional authority are treated as real leadership systems worth analysing, not just cultural background.
- **Cover the theoretical foundations** — the major leadership theories (trait, contingency, situational, path-goal) that show up repeatedly in the reading list and in exams.
- **Understand situational leader selection** — why the "right" leader for one situation may be the wrong one for another.
- **Evaluate decision-making models** — practical frameworks for how leaders should decide, not just how they do decide.
- **Identify relevant leadership styles** — matching a style (autocratic, participative, etc.) to a context.
- **Advise organisations on leadership approaches** — this is the applied, case-study side of the course.
- **Build your own leadership competencies** — the course expects some self-reflection, not just external analysis.

3. Learning Outcomes — What You'll Be Tested On

These mirror the objectives above, but they're the actual skills you need walking into the exam: grasping core leadership concepts, analysing theory, determining what situational factors matter, identifying decision-making models, recognising which leadership style fits which context, and being able to

recommend an approach for a given organisation. If you can do all six comfortably, you're exam-ready.

4. Week-by-Week Breakdown

This is the actual roadmap for the semester. Use it to plan revision *before* it piles up.

Week 1 — Foundations of Leadership

The starting point: what leadership actually is, its functions (roles, duties, responsibilities), the different levels of leadership, and — a common exam trap — the difference vs. the overlap between leadership and management.

Week 2 — Theories of Leadership

Covers why theory matters at all, then the classic models: Great Man Theory, Trait Theory, the Managerial Grid, and Expectation Theory (Pygmalion effect). Expect to compare these against each other.

Week 3 — Contemporary Theories of Leadership

The more advanced, "it depends" theories: Fiedler's Contingency Model, Hersey and Blanchard's Situational Leadership, and Path-Goal Theory. These build directly on Week 2, so don't skip ahead without it.

Week 4 — Leadership in Practice & Governance

Leadership in different real-world contexts, the challenges and opportunities leaders face, leadership development as a lifelong process, and how leadership connects to social responsibility and organisational culture.

Week 5 — Trust and Power in Leadership

Trust is treated as something leaders actively build and maintain, not something they're owed. Also covers where power comes from (sources and types) and how trust and power work together.

Week 6 — Traditional Leadership

A Ghana-specific week: the architecture of traditional leadership, the scope of what traditional leaders actually do, the misconceptions ("the myth") around them, and their formal roles — this draws directly on constitutional and legal sources, so check the reading list for this week closely.

Week 7 — Leadership Styles and Skills

The practical skillset: forms of leadership style, administrative and interpersonal skills, communication skills, and why having the right skills matters as much as having the right style.

Week 8 — Mid-Semester Examination

Covers everything from Weeks 1–7. This is the point where gaps become obvious — worth reviewing Weeks 1–3 especially, since later weeks build on them.

Week 9 — Decision-Making Models and Styles

Why decisions matter so much in leadership, the role intelligence and experience play, and the named models: the Cognitive Resources Model, Rational vs. Incremental decision-making, and Vroom and

Yetton's Normative Model.

Week 10 — Leading Teams and Crisis Management

What actually separates a team from a group, why people join groups in the first place, the stages teams go through as they develop, how to lead a team well (including virtual teams), and leading specifically during a crisis.

Week 11 — Ethical Leadership and Values

The concept of ethics in leadership, the difference between morality and ethics, principles of ethical leadership, and how to actually make an ethical decision when values conflict.

Week 12 — Revision and Reconciliation of Assessment

Final review week — a chance to reconcile any assessment discrepancies and consolidate the whole semester before the final exam.

5. How You're Assessed

Your final grade is split 40% Interim Assessment and 60% Final Exam. Here's what actually makes up each part:

Component	Weight	What it covers
Lecturer's quizzes / group work / presentations / attendance	20 marks	Set individually by your lecturer — could be quizzes, group assignments, or presentations.
General Interim Assessment (IA)	20 marks	A multiple-choice test via Google Forms, covering Weeks 1–8.
Final Exam — Section A	part of 60%	20 compulsory multiple-choice questions.
Final Exam — Section B	part of 60%	4 essay questions offered, answer 3.

In plain terms: your day-to-day quizzes and participation are worth just as much as one whole section of the final exam. Skipping interim quizzes to "focus on the exam" is a losing trade.

Academic Honesty

The course outline is explicit that academic dishonesty carries a heavy penalty and damages your standing — this isn't boilerplate, it's enforced. Don't cheat, and don't help others cheat.

6. Core Reading List

You don't need to buy every book on this list — treat it as a reference set to dip into per week, matched against the week-by-week breakdown above.

- Northouse, P. G. (2021). *Leadership: Theory and Practice* (9th ed.). Sage — the most-cited text across nearly every week; if you only get one book, get this one.
- Golensky, M., & Hager, M. (2020). *Strategic Leadership and Management in Nonprofit Organisations*. Oxford University Press.
- Salih, A. (2020). *Cross-Cultural Leadership*. Routledge.
- Government of Ghana (1992). *Constitution of the Republic of Ghana* — specifically relevant to Week 6 (Traditional Leadership).
- Mickahail, B. K. (2019). *Effective and Creative Leadership in Diverse Workforces*. Palgrave Macmillan.

Academic Exchange Forum — study materials built by students, for students. More notes, quizzes, and past questions for this course will be posted to the site as the semester progresses.